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Shadab Bano

The age of marriage besides providing a valuable index for the study of gender-relations in the society and its socio-cultural milieu is also an important aspect of demographic. The present study takes up primarily the age of marriage as found in the Mughal Imperial family as the official historians record the births of princes and princesses and their marriages quite often. In comparison, the information for aristocratic and other families tends to be meagre. Marriages of noble's daughters to princes find frequent mention but their age at marriage becomes difficult to ascertain.

The marriages in the imperial family in India is well documented by Babur and Gulbadan, who provide more or less full information on Babur's marriages and that of his children. Both of them discuss also the marriages of many of the Timurid princes, princesses and the nobles, which could further supplement the data for the early Mughals in India.

Babur (b.1483) was married for the first time in 1500 at the age of 17 to Ayisha Sultan, his first cousin (to whom he was betrothed when he was 5 years old).¹ The marriage reported of his brother, Jahangir Mirza (b. 1485) was in the year 1504-5 (to a daughter of Sultan Mahmud Mirza) when he was 19-20 years old which was perhaps his first marriage, as he was engaged to the same girl way back in the year 1495-96.² Of Babur's sons, the year of Humayun's (b.1508) first marriage (to Bega/Haji Begum) though not known, we know that his first child was born in 1528 when he was 20.³ Similarly Kamran born in a year between 1508 to 1511 (his birth not mentioned in *Baburnama*. Gulbadan mentions him amongst Babur's children when he proceeded to Kabul in 1511) was married in 1528,⁴ that is at the age of 17-20 years and Hindal (b.1519) was married in 1537, 18 years of age.⁵ On an average 18 years was thus the marriage age for Askari's men in this period. (Akbar's age at marriage could not be worked out.

Similarly, the age of marriage of girls of Mughal imperial family does not appear low, by medieval standards, as we will see. Taking Babur's wives first: Babur married Ayisha Sultan in 1500 and by her had a child in 1501 (definitely a grown up girl, her age at marriage must not have been lower than 13 and most likely 14-15 years, as

we know Babur was five at his engagement in 1488).⁶ His marriage to Maham Begum took place in 1506-7 and her first child, Humayun was born in 1508.⁷ They were thus in their puberty. With Masuma whom he married in 1507, it was a mutual attraction when they met a year before.⁸ She must have been in her teens already. Similar was the case with his other wife, Bibi Mubarika (Gulbadan's Afghani Agacha) by whom he was particularly enamoured. He enquired about her age and whether she was betrothed, so that he could marry her.⁹ (About his other wives, nothing could be said with certainty).¹⁰ The age of marriage of his daughters is more clear. Gulrang (b. 1511-15) was married in 1530 (i.e. between 15-19 years).¹¹ Gulchihra was married when she was 14 years old.¹² Gulbadan born in 1523 was not a married woman in 1537 and thus was married only after her fourteenth year.¹³ The average age of marriage for women in this period thus comes to around fourteen years i.e. around the age of puberty.¹⁴ The instance of betrothal much before the marriage, clearly, suggest that the girls were not married before attaining puberty. We see the girl and the boy waiting till they reached puberty; at a time when they could bear children.

However, there appear some exceptions to this practice. Agha Begum, daughter of Sultan Husain Mirza Bayqra was married as a child, and it is reported that she died before reaching maturity.¹⁵ Babur's daughter Masuma was married when she was 9 years old to Muhammad Zaman Mirza Bayqra who was 21.¹⁶ She was however not sent to Balkh with her husband when he returned to Balkh. There was thus great difference of age also between them. Otherwise the normal age difference would not have been much if we consider the 1st marriage and the average marriageable age of groom as 18 and that of bride 14. Besides in a polygamous system where the age difference between men and his other wives automatically grew with each successive marriage;¹⁷ among the Timurids and early Mughals in India, we strikingly find the remarriages of women also after separation, divorce or death of husband being a common feature¹⁸ and they remarried not only when they were quite young but sometimes even after thirty,¹⁹ in which cases the differences would not have been major.

Noting the rare instances, it was not only the girls who were married sometimes in their childhood. We find Humayun planning Akbar's marriage with Kamran's daughter (in 1550) when he was only 8.²⁰ These sort of marriages were however sought for their political advantages. We can understand Humayun's difficulties in this period and his anxiety to improve relationships and win friends

for the reconquest of India by all means. He also got his 10 year old daughter Bakhshi Banu married to Ibrahim, son of Mirza Sulaiman, ruler of Badakhshan around this period and himself sought Mirza Sulaiman's daughter who was also a minor, at that time.²¹ Akbar's marriage to Kamran's daughter could not materialise, still he was married at an early age. His first marriage being with Ruqayya Sultan, Hilda's daughter which took place before he married the daughter of Abdullah Khan Mughal in 1557 when he was only 15 years old.²²

On coming of age, Akbar is reported to have married many wives, "both free born and concubines."²³ In 1562, he for the first time married a Hindu princess, daughter of Bihari Mal of Amber (a Kachwah princess). We know nothing about the age at which Hindu wives entered Akbar's harem.²⁴ However, there has been a general perception about child marriages being common among Hindus in India,²⁵ and the view that Rajput marriages took place very early.

Ardhakathanak, a biography of a Jain merchant, Banarsidas, actually brings forth instances of a number of child marriages, which show how common it was in the prevailing society. Banarsidas was wedded when he was 11 years old and his bride at this age came along with him to his house.²⁶ (the children born to Banarsi died in infancy). He had two sisters, both of whom were married when they were 10 years old.²⁷ Infact, when the younger one was still unmarried, the family was anxiously looking for a groom.

However, it appears that the Rajput marriages of princesses occurred to the Mughal princes only after attaining the age, as is indicated by the case of Raja Bhagwan Das' daughter (Shah Begum) Salim's first wife²⁸ and Aurangzeb's wife, Nawab Bai (the only instances forthcoming for Rajput princess' age at marriage). Shah Begum was married to Salim in 1584, she became a mother in 1585 and gave birth to children consecutively in 1586, 1587.²⁹ While Nawab Bai, the daughter of Raja of Rajouri state in Kashmir of hill-Rajput blood) was married to Aurangzeb after 1537 (the year of Aurangzeb's first marriage to Dildar Banu, a Persian princess), and her first child Muhammad Sultan was born in 1539. These were definitely not child marriages.³⁰

By 1586-87, Akbar had come out, with his ordinances and had censured the child marriages.³¹ Boys should not marry before 16, and the girls not before 14, as according to him, the offspring of early marriages are weak. Of his children, Salim was married at the age of 15, Murad was 17 and Danyal was 16.³² Akbar paid full attention to Murad's marriage when he reached the age of 17. No marriage before puberty was admitted, states Abul Fazl.³³ Similarly,

Jahangir's sons were married — Khusrau at 15 (b.1587, m.1602), Perwiz at 16-17 (b.1587, m. 1605-06), Khurram at 18 (b.1592, m.1610) and Shahryaar at 15 (b.1605, m.1620).³⁴

Interestingly, from Akbar's time, we find daughters married at a very late age and sometimes not even married. Shahzada Khanam, his eldest daughter (b.1569) was married in 1594, at the age of 25 to Muzaffar Hussain Mirza, Kamran's grandson and her cousin.³⁵ Another daughter Shahr-un-Nisa (born after Danyal's birth in 1572) also married in 1594 (to Shahrukh Mirza from royal family) must have been in her early twenties or late teens by that time.³⁶ Aram Banu, Akbar's most favourite daughter (b. 1584) died unmarried in Jahangir's reign.³⁷ With the enhanced imperial prestige vis-a-vis nobility, during Akbar's time,³⁸ it became increasingly difficult to find suitable matches for princesses. Earlier we find daughters of royal family given to to Mughal nobles without any hesitation.

Of the surviving daughters of Jahangir, Nisa Begum and Bihar Begum, we know only of Bihar Begum's marriage. She was married to her cousin Tahmuras, Danyal's son, even though younger to her in age. (She was born in 1590 and Tahmuras only after that year as in 1590 Danyal's first child, a daughter was born).³⁹ The daughter of Murad was married to Perwez's son.⁴⁰ Danyal's daughter, Bulaqi Begum was married (in 1619) to Mirza Wali, son of Jahangir's aunt.⁴¹ The marriages between cousins and within the royal family became more frequent now.

In Shah Jahan's time, the problem of finding matches became acute and we clearly could see it as a part of imperial policy not to marry princesses. Both his daughters, Jahanara and Roshanara were left unmarried. Out of Aurangzeb's five daughters, only two could be married Zubdatun Nisa at the age of 22 (to Sipahr Shikoh, son of Dara Shikoh).⁴² Strangely enough he got his youngest daughter, Mihr-un-Nisa, married to son of Murad Bakhsh when she was only 11 years old⁴³ (this being the only instance of an early marriage from amongst the references of princess' marriage which already becomes scarce in the 17th century). The evidence for the age at which the daughter of Murad Bakhsh and Sulaiman Shikoh were married. Both the girls were married in 1678 to their cousins when they could not have been less than 18 and 17 years of age (if we take the years of their fathers' death as the years of their birth respectively).⁴⁴ The references generally speak of late marriages and that too with the cousins only. Otherwise, there is silence over daughter's marriages while the sons' multiple marriages are discussed throughout.

Shah Jahan's sons were married around 18 years of age, if we take the average: Dara at 18, Shah Shuja at 17, Aurangzeb at 19, Murad Bakhsh 18.⁴⁵ A number of princes of the next generation were nevertheless also married at a younger age. Aurangzeb's sons, Muhammad Azam and Akbar were married at 15, Kambaksh at 14, Prince Muazzam's sons at 14 and 15.⁴⁶

Princes' marriage to nobles' daughters also was not uncommon. The noble's daughters visiting the royal harem could be easily approached by the princes, which sometimes became a matter of concern. For instance, as the niece of Zain Khan Koka was already married to Salim, Akbar did not approve of Salim's marriage with Zain Khan's daughter. But Salim's insistence on marrying her made Akbar yield on the matter.⁴⁷ Similarly, it is reported that Salim fell in love with Mihr-un-Nisa in his adolescence (before her marriage to Sher Afghan) when she used to come to the palace to attend feasts and entertainments. Akbar got her secretly married to Sher Afghan when the matter became known to him. These girls must have been in their adolescence to be attractive enough. For Nur Jahan, we know that her teens had just started (b. in 1581, the episode appears to be of sometime after the Thatta campaign 1591-92).⁴⁸ In this manner we also could gain some idea of the age the nobles got their daughters married (which was clearly not in childhood).

NOTES AND REFERENCES

1. *Baburnama*, tr. A.S. Beveridge, London, reprint 1989, p.35.
2. *Ibid.*, p.48; Gulbadan Begum, *Humayun Nama*, ed. and tr. A.S. Beveridge, *The History of Humayun*, London, 1902, reprint Delhi, 1994, p.206.
3. Abul Fazl, *Akbarnama*, ed. Agha Ahmad Ali and Abdur Rahim, 3 vols., Bib. Ind., Calcutta, 1873-87; p.114.
4. *Humayun Nama*, ed. op.cit., p.9. Beveridge has put Kamran's birth in the year 9140-915 H/1509. See *Baburnama*, Appendix J, p.xxxv, p.619.
5. Jauhar, *Ta'kirat-ul-Waqiat*, Add. 16, 711, f.12b.
6. *Baburnama*, p.35. Among Timurids, brides could also be of same age or even older to groom as was the case with Babur's aunt, Khub-nigar who was a year elder to her husband. (*Humayun Nama*), p.253.
7. *Humayun Nama*, p.258; *Baburnama*, p.344. In Beveridge's there is a misprint in the date 1506 instead of 1508.
8. *Baburnama*, p.306.
9. *Ibid.*, pp.375-76. Appendix K entitled Afghan Legend (pp.xxxvi-xli) appended to *Baburnama*, brings out details of the affair from *Tawarikh-i Hafi-i Rahmat kham*.
10. About his other wives, Gulrukh and Dildar nothing could be said with certainty.
11. *Humayun Nama*, pp.232-3.